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Personality and learning: An investigation into students' personality development as an outcome of the Lebanese education system

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Abstract
The purpose of this study was to measure and compare the Big Five personality traits of students attending the Public secondary schools of Mount-Lebanon and the Suburbs of Beirut, Lebanon and to shed light on the most important outcome of the Lebanese education system: student's personality development. The study is conducted using a quantitative questionnaire about the Big Five personality traits, that are (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness, Agreeableness, and Conscientiousness), which is asked for a random sample of 500 students. The most noteworthy findings were: the ratio of the students' personality traits of Conscientiousness and Extraversion are more dominant as compared to the remaining three Big Five personality traits; the Conscientiousness personality trait is the most dominant, whereas Neuroticism is the least dominant personality trait; and there was a significant difference between male and female students in two big personality traits (Conscientiousness and Agreeableness).

Keywords: personality, neuroticism, extraversion, agreeableness, openness to experience and conscientiousness

1. Introduction

Personality refers to individual differences in characteristic patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving [1]. The study of personality focuses on two broad areas. The first area is the understanding of individual differences, in particular, personality characteristics such as sociability or irritability. The second is the understanding of how the various parts of a person come together as a whole.

Personality can also be defined as the dynamic organization of these traits and the characteristic patterns of behavior that are unique to the individual [2]. The trait theory of personality is one that focuses on identifying, describing, and measuring individual differences [3]. Trait theories do not assume that some people have a trait and others do not; rather, they propose that all people have certain traits, but that the degree to which the trait applies to a specific person varies and can be quantified [4]. So, a person may be extremely sociable, somewhat sociable, or not sociable at all. Therefore, a trait is described in terms of a range extending from one extreme to its opposite. Traits on the other hand are enduring dimensions of personality characteristics which differentiate people from one another [5]. We can say that a trait is simply a behavioral blueprint - an outlook or propensity to behave in a describable way.

A trait (1) is more widespread than a habit, (2) is forceful and determinative in behavior, (3) may be viewed either in the light of the personality that contains it, or in the light of its division in the population at large, and (4) cannot be proved nonexistent by the absolute reality that some acts are incoherent with it [6]. Trait can be defined as a property within the individual that accounts for his unique but relatively stable reactions to the environment [7]. Therefore, conformity, consistency and continuity are characteristics of the behaviour of individuals for it is shaped by their personality traits. Research on student personality development is based on the assumption that students can acquire more than knowledge and skills during the teaching-learning process; they can also acquire attitudes and develop their personality traits. Personality influences the behavior of the students in different fields, such as their interactions with colleagues, interactions with teachers, as well as their motivation, academic achievement, and learning. Becoming aware of one's own personality type and the personality type of others can be helpful in mounting intra-personal and inter-personal development. Personality recognition has been used for many purposes in various organizations: to forecast a worker's aptitude to fill definite roles; to set up pleasant-sounding relationships; to conclude team effectiveness; and to predict future behaviour [8]. Personal characteristics of acquiring new knowledge and achieving success in learning depend on the intellectual development of the students and the overall structure of the personality of the student [9]. The science of education is an area of expertise formed on the basis of two notions, "education" and "instruction"; Education is the activity that enables new generations to obtain the necessary information, abilities, attitudes and understanding and develop their character while preparing them for communal life [10]. The school environment, alongside the family, plays an important role in developing students' personality, since it is the first site of socialization for the child. This makes it the duty of the education system to be effective in not just the students' intellectual development, but also their character development. Schools and teachers should educate for the sake of improving character, especially by teaching the importance of respect and responsibility [11]. A person of character has the wisdom to differentiate between right and

wrong, good and bad; is honest, trustworthy, fair, respectful, and responsible. The person also admits and learns from his/her mistakes, and most of these traits can be categorized under the Big Five personality traits.

Character encompasses being good and doing right, whereas those who do not abide by ethical principles exhibit the opposite of "character". The ultimate goal of character development occurs when each person reaches the point where doing "good" becomes automatic and habitual [12]. Hence, this behaviour becomes related to their personalities and helps nurture their traits.

Some social psychologists state that personality is entirely a matter of social awareness, so someone's personality cannot be separately defined from the social context he or she behaves in, such as the people they interact with and who formulate an impression about them, and use trait terms in unfolding the person [13]. This fact is consistent with the previous definition of a trait and its characteristics. Each individual has characteristic attributes of personality that manipulate both the manner in which he or she behaves toward others and the ways in which they act in response to him or her. Personality facilitates the teaching-learning process, for communication takes place between the teacher and the learner even in the absence of the spoken word (nonverbal communication). Positive teacher-student relationships, evidenced by teachers' reports of low conflict, a high degree of closeness and support, and little dependency, have been shown to support students' adjustment to school, contribute to their social skills, promote academic performance, and foster students' resiliency in academic performance [14]. Research shows that learning in the classroom is an emotional experience, and that the younger the people, the truer this statement is [15]. The process of learning in the classroom is accompanied and accelerated by positive affect and a relaxed atmosphere. For example, the teacher with invasive dictatorial characteristics is likely to reproduce these characteristics in their relationships with students and in their teaching techniques [16].

Teachers are cognitively leaning toward pupils while pupils are affectively sloping toward teachers [17]. Teacher personality is, therefore, straightforwardly and indirectly related to learning and teaching in the affective domain, as well as the cognitive and psychomotor domains.

By exhibiting good behaviours related to agreeable traits and acting as role model in front of his students, a teacher can stimulate the process of developing these agreeable traits in their personailities.

When the words and the deeds of a teacher are consistent, the first message he conveys to his students is the importance of Honesty in human interactions, this helps build students 'positive attitudes towards it and encourage them to behave in an honest way and ultimately stimulating the development of this trait in their personality. However, there has been an increasing interest in the Big Five personality traits and the role they play regarding not only the academic achievement of students, but their personality development as well.

Of particular interest is the continuous process of assessing the education system by its two major and important outcomes: the academic achievement and personality development of secondary school students. By doing so, we can measure the education system effectiveness in order to improve it.

Research has emphasized that the 'Big Five Personality Traits' of Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness and Conscientiousness, all play a role in developing traits suitable for a healthy personality.

2. Statement of the problem

The search to know why people behave the way they do has led to large amounts of research. In order to answer some of these questions, personality psychologists have developed a sophisticated model of personality that is known as 'trait theory'.

A trait can be defined as a continuous dimension on which individual differences may be arranged quantitatively in terms of the amount of the characteristics the individual has [18]. In addition, it is also can be defined trait as a property within the individual that accounts for his unique but relatively stable reactions to the environment [7]. Other personality theorists emphasize the role of biological, cognitive and environmental forces in shaping personality. Personality description is not the main goal of these theorists; instead their goal is to explain personality and behavior in terms of their underlying causes.

2.1 Personality theory of Jung

The personality theory of Jung assumes that people are dissimilar from each other in realistic types consisting of pairs of opposites [19]. The first pair describes the way people gain their energy. Some people are thrilled to interact with others and are tuned to the outer world of measures. Others are more thoughtful with the inner self and are thrilled by their own judgment and thoughts. These two boundaries are termed Extraversion (E) and Introversion (I). The second pair in Jung's theory relates to the way individuals recognize and acquire information. These avenues of gaining are termed Sensing (S) and Intuition (N). Individuals that are geared towards the Sensing direction tend to carefully examine

Table 1: Big five traits facet

Big Five Traits	Facet (and correlated trait adjective)
Extraversion vs. introversion	–Gregariousness (sociable) –Assertiveness (forceful) –Activity (energetic) –Excitement-seeking (adventurous) –Positive emotions (enthusiastic) –Warmth (outgoing).
Agreeableness vs. antagonism	–Trust (forgiving) –Straightforwardness (not demanding) –Altruism (warm)

	–Compliance (not stubborn) –Modesty (not show-off) –Tender-mindedness (sympathetic)
Conscientiousness vs. lack of direction	–Competence (efficient) –Order (organized) –Dutifulness (not careless) –Achievement striving (thorough) –Self-discipline (not lazy) –Deliberation (not impulsive)
Neuroticism vs. emotional stability	–Anxiety (tense) –Angry hostility (irritable) –Depression (not contented) –Self-consciousness (shy) –Impulsiveness (moody) –Vulnerability (not self-confident)
Openness vs. closedness to experience	–Ideas (curious) –Fantasy (imaginative) –Aesthetics (artistic) –Actions (wide interests) –Feelings (excitable) –Values (unconventional)

Information and employ all of their senses in their investigations. They are reality based and are thorough in investigating the data they have carefully collected. Individuals who are spontaneous (N's) rely on their instincts and trust their "sixth sense" to collect information. The third pairs in Jung's theory relate to the approaches of making decisions. These approaches are labeled Thinking (T) and Feeling (F). Thinkers are objective, logical and reasonable, and consider data in reaching conclusions. They are able to suspend their personal feelings when they logically resolve a dilemma. In contrast, Feelers are subjective and thoughtful of the sentimental outcomes of the precise situation. Feelers consider how their decisions will affect others.

2.2 Myers and Briggs's theory of personality

Myers and Briggs [20] elaborated on Jung's theory by adding the Judgment/ Perception polarities. These functions indicate the mode in which people act together and with the environment. Judgers (J) prefer an organized and stable environment, and strive to regulate and manage their lives. On the other hand, Perceivers (P) are elastic and impulsive and prefer to stay open to opportunities that unfold.

2.3 Five-Factor Model of personality (Big Five model)

The most common version of the Five-Factor Model (FFM) or the big five model is the one developed by P. Costa and R. McCrae [21], which is based on a number of previous studies [22, 23, 24]. The FFM framework states that the factors (also referred to as 'traits') are orthogonal and each of them is comprised of six facets. The FFM includes factors such as Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness and Conscientiousness, which are described in the literature [21, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29]. The FFM framework is widely used across many countries to study relations between personal traits and various aspects of social behavior, including Hofstede's cultural dimensions, one's attitude towards health, learning processes, profession, computer gaming, etc. [26, 27, 30, 31, 32].

Big five traits facet (and correlated trait adjective): The Big Five Factors are (chart recreated from John & Srivastava [33]):

Recently, a considerable amount of empirical research based on the Big Five model, and aimed at the detection of associations between academic achievement and personality traits in students, was conducted.

There are more than a few reasons for attributing such enormous importance to the personality of a student. The first and leading reason is that the personality of students influences their academic motivation, academic performance, their interaction with other colleagues and teachers, as well as their future behaviour in society.

When the psychological traits of personality are achieved within the student, one is more likely to be motivated to achieve, cooperate and take on new challenges. One's personality traits play an important role in one's behavior, even in childhood. They also influence not only the goals individual set for their selves, but also the ways in which one goes about achieving these goals.

A high predictive power of the Big Five traits in evaluating academic achievement was discovered [34, 35]. It was also established that Conscientiousness and Openness are highly associated with academic achievement in high school and university students [35].

There is evidence that personality traits can predict academic motivation and achievement [21]. Motivation can be considered as a core trait in the Big Five factor model of personality knowing that conscientious individuals are organized, hardworking, self-disciplined, ambitious and persevering [36]. In addition, motivation has an important influence on a learner's learning behavior and achievement.

Results showed that Conscientiousness, in particular, to be most strongly and consistently associated with academic success [37]. As mentioned above, Conscientiousness is introduced as a predictor of academic achievement [21, 36].

There are a number of studies on Conscientiousness's

influence on academic motivation [38] and academic performance [39, 40, 41]. Wagerman and Funder [42] count the Conscientiousness factor as a valid and unique predictor of college performance. Prior research also confirms the role of Openness to experience as one of the main personality factors that predict academic motivation and academic performance [39, 43]. There is ample evidence [44, 45] of the significant correlations between academic motivation and academic performance.

Research on students' personality is based on the assumption that the student as a person is a significant factor in the teaching-learning process. Personality influences the behavior of the student in diverse ways, such as in interactions with other students and teachers, motivation to learn, overall academic performance, and their future behaviour in life, and in general, as a member of society.

The aforementioned literature related to students' personalites and its importance suggests that a lot of research has been conducted to investigate the personality traits of students, but unfortunately no specific research has been conducted in Lebanon. Specifically, there has not been a study conducted to measure the personality traits of students attending Public Secondary schools in Lebanon. This study was conducted to address this gap in research. Thus it is aimed to aimed to measure the personality traits of students attending Public Secondary schools in Lebanon.

3. Objectives of the study

The following were the main objectives of the study:

1. To examine the ratio of the Big Five personality traits (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness) of students at public secondary schools in Lebanon.
2. To compare the Big Five personality traits (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness) of male and female students at public secondary schools in Lebanon.
3. To put forward some useful suggestions and strategies to improve the quality of the Lebanese education system and its processes, mainly the teaching-learning process in terms of its capability to develop students' personality.

4. Research questions of the study

In consistence with the objectives, the following research questions were posed:

1. To what extent are all the Big Five personality traits (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness) present in students attending public secondary schools in Lebanon?
2. Is there any significant difference in the Big Five personality traits (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness) between male and female students attending public secondary schools in Lebanon?

5. Hypotheses of the study

For the second research question posed above, the following hypotheses were formulated:

H_{01}: There is no significant difference between male and female students in the Neuroticism trait of their personality.

H_{02}: There is no significant difference between male and female students in the Extraversion trait of their personality.

H_{03}: There is no significant difference between male and female students in the Openness trait of their personality.

H_{04}: There is no significant difference between male and female students in the Agreeableness trait of their personality.

H_{05}: There is no significant difference between male and female students in the Conscientiousness trait of their personality.

6. Significance of the study

Research has established that a person is characterized by the levels of his personality traits. How and why an individual differs from another is an important part of the study of personality [46].

Students enjoying a healthy classroom atmosphere are able to develop and improve all the aspects of their personality levels. It is important for a student- who will one day be an active member of society- to have a sound personality that will affect how effective they are in the society. It is also important to find out whether the education system plays a vital role in shaping the personality of students. This study wants to investigate a major and important outcome of the Lebanese education system by studying its contribution to developing the personality of students attending public secondary schools in Lebanon.

7. Methodology and Procedure

7.1 Type of the study

The study is descriptive in nature. A descriptive research also known as statistical research, describes data and characteristics about the population and phenomenon being studied. The purpose of this study was to measure and compare the Big Five personality traits of male and female students at public secondary schools in Lebanon.

7.2 Population and sampling

The population surveyed consisted of all students attending public secondary schools in Mount-Lebanon and the Suburbs of Beirut, Lebanon.

A random sampling technique was used to randomly select seven schools out of 30 public secondary schools located in Mount-Lebanon and the Suburbs of Beirut and the students were also randomly selected from these seven schools in order to have a sample of 500 students (240 Females & 260 Males).

7.3 Study Instrument

The investigators utilized the Big Five Inventory (BFI) instrument to measure teachers' personality traits. This inventory was deduced from the Big Five Inventory (BFI) that was originally developed by Robert McCrae and Paul Costa [47], and then translated into Arabic by Alansari [48] with little modification. This was distributed amongst the selected students.

The BFI has been used frequently in research settings. The "Big Five" factors of personality are five broad traits/domains/dimensions of personality that are used to describe human personality. These Big five personality traits are Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness and Conscientiousness. These five factors

provide a rich conceptual framework for integrating all the research findings and theory in personality psychology. This inventory comprised of sixty statements about personality traits (twelve statements about each personality trait). It consisted of a 5 points Likert Scale. The response categories of each of the questions were in descending order of weighting: Strongly Agree (5 points), Agree (4 points), Neutral (3 points), Disagree (2 points), and Strongly Disagree (1 points). The Cronbach's alpha coefficients used to test reliability were (0.72), (0.78), (0.71), (0.73) for Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness, Agreeableness Conscientiousness, respectively.

Respondents were asked to indicate their level of agreement with each statement on the inventory. Collected data was analyzed by using simple descriptive and inferential statistical techniques such as the mean, standard deviation, and t- test.

8. Results

8.1 Research Question 1.

Table 2: Mean score of the students on big five personality traits

Personality Trait	Mean(M)	Standard Deviation (SD)
Neuroticism	2.79	0.62
Openness	3.15	0.55
Agreeableness	3.2	0.6
Extraversion	3.6	0.61
Conscientiousness	3.61	0.7

Table 2. Shows that the mean scores of students at public secondary schools for two personality traits (Extraversion and Conscientiousness) are nearly the same and greater than other mean scores. It also shows that the mean score for Neuroticism is the smallest mean score. This means that the students' personality traits of Conscientiousness and Extraversion are more dominant as compared to the remaining three Big Five personality traits and that the Conscientiousness personality trait is the most dominant, whereas Neuroticism is the least dominant personality trait.

8.2 Research Question 2.

H_0:$_1$ there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Neuroticism trait of their personality.

Table 3: T-test analysis between male and female students and personality trait of neuroticism

Gender	Personality Trait	Mean	t-value	P Sig.(2-tailed)	Decision
Male (n1=260)	Neuroticism	2.79	-0.511	0.610	Null hypothesis accepted
Female (n2=240)	Neuroticism	2.82			

Table 3 shows that the mean score of male students is less than the mean score of female students in their Neuroticism personality trait. It also shows that the observed probability is 0.610, which is greater than 0.05 probabilities for a 2- tailed test.

Thus, the null hypothesis H_0:$_1$(that there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Neuroticism trait of their personality is accepted.

This means that there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Neuroticism trait of their personality. However, as reported in the Table 3, female students are more neurotic than male students though the difference is not statistically significant.

H_0:$_2$ there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Extraversion trait of their personality.

Table 4: T-test Analysis between male and female students and Personality trait of Extraversion

Gender	Personality Trait	Mean	t-value	P Sig.(2-tailed)	Decision
Male (n1=260)	Extraversion	3.57	0.635	0.526	Null hypothesis accepted
Female (n2=240)	Extraversion	3.53			

Table 4 shows that the mean score of female students is less than the mean score of male students in their Extraversion personality trait. It also shows that the observed probability is 0.526, which is greater than 0.05 probabilities for a 2- tailed test.

So the null hypothesis $H_{0:2}$ (there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Extraversion trait of their personality) is accepted.

This means that there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Extraversion trait of their personality. However, as reported in the Table 4, male students are more extroverted than female students, though the difference is not statistically significant.

$H_{0:3}$ there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Openness trait of their personality.

Table 5: T-test Analysis between male and female students and Personality trait of Openness

Gender	Personality Trait	Mean	t-value	P Sig.(2-tailed)	Decision
Male (n1=260)	Openness	3.11	-1.654	0.099	Null hypothesis accepted

Female (n2=240)	Openness	3.20			

Table 5 shows that the mean score of male students is less than the mean score of female students in their Openness personality trait. It also shows that the observed probability is 0.099, which is greater than 0.05 probabilities for a 2- tailed test.

So, the null hypothesis $H_{0:3}$ (there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Openness trait of their personality) is accepted.

It means that there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Openness trait of their personality. However, as reported in Table 5, female students are more open than male students, though the difference is not statistically significant.

$H_{0:4}$ there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Agreeableness trait of their personality.

Table 6: T-test Analysis between male and female students and Personality trait of Agreeableness

Gender	Personality Trait	Mean	t-value	P Sig.(2-tailed)	Decision
Male (n1=260)	Agreeableness	3.10	-3.096	0.002	Null hypothesis rejected
Female (n2=240)	Agreeableness	3.30			

Table 6 shows that the mean score of male students is less than the mean score of female students in their Agreeableness personality trait. It also shows that the observed probability is 0.002, which is less than 0.05 probabilities for a 2- tailed test.

So the null hypothesis $H_{0:4}$ (there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Agreeableness trait of their personality) is rejected.

This means that there is a significant difference between male and female students in the Agreeableness trait of their personality. This also means that female students are more agreeable than male students.

$H_{0:5}$ there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Conscientiousness trait of their personality.

Table 7: T-test Analysis between male and female students and Personality trait of Conscientiousness

Gender	Personality Trait	Mean	t-value	P Sig.(2-tailed)	Decision
Male (n1=260)	Conscientiousness	3.54	-2.728	0.007	Null hypothesis rejected
Female (n2=240)	Conscientiousness	3.74			

Table 7 shows that the mean score of male students is less than the mean score of female students in their Conscientiousness personality trait. It also shows that the observed probability is 0.007, which is less than 0.05 probabilities for a 2- tailed test.

Thus, the null hypothesis $H_{0:5}$ (there is no significant difference between male and female students in the Conscientiousness trait of their personality) is rejected.

This means that there is a significant difference between male and female students in the Conscientiousness trait of their personality. It also means that female students are more conscientious than male students.

9. Discussion

In the first phase of this study, we examined the mean values of each of the Big Five Personality traits by answering research question 1 (See Table 2).

The results show that Conscientiousness, with mean equals (3.61), is the most dominant trait in the sample, followed closely by Extraversion, with mean equals (3.6), then by Agreeableness, with mean equals (3.2), and Openness with mean equals (3.15). The results also showed that Neuroticism, with mean equals (2.79) is the least dominant trait in the sample. These results match the results of a research on student's personality conducted on Russian students [49].

We can conclude that the students at Public secondary schools in Lebanon are conscientious, i.e. good at organizing their work, managing their time and studying hard with clear goals [7]. Conscientiousness has been linked to educational achievement and particularly to the will to achieve [50]. Those who are conscientious are expected to be successful in their work or careers. In work settings, recent research has demonstrated that managers perceive cognitive ability and Conscientiousness as the most important attributes related to whether or not an applicant is hirable [51].

Since they score high on Extraversion as well, they are usually sociable, talkative and communicative, and friendly. They also have an intrinsic motivation and a positive attitude [52]. Furthermore, they are described as active, bold, assertive, exciting, and stimulating [23, 47].

Regarding Neuroticism, students scored low on it in comparison to the other Big Five personality traits. Neuroticism had a mean close to the average, and so we can then conclude that they are usually calm, even-tempered and relaxed at work in school. They also have lower levels of anxiety and depression in their personal lives, which can hinder them from being academically motivated and good performers in their studies. The results also show that:

- There is a significant difference between male and female students in the Conscientiousness trait of their personality. The mean score of female students is greater than the mean score of male students in their Conscientiousness personality trait. This means that female students are dominant over male students in their Conscientiousness personality trait.
- There is a significant difference between the male and female students in the Agreeableness trait of their personality. The mean score of female students is greater than the mean score of male students in their Agreeableness personality trait. This means that female students are dominant over male students in their Agreeableness personality trait.

- There is no significant difference between male and female students in the remaining three Big Five personality traits of Extraversion, Openness and Neuroticism.

Previous research data suggests a degree of gender differences in the mean values of these traits. In a given sample, women only show higher mean values for the two big personality traits of Conscientiousness and Agreeableness compared to men. The reason for this significant difference may be due to a natural tendency of Agreeableness in females because their innate nature is to be kind, merciful, forgiving and understanding. As well, there is a societal tendency of Conscientiousness to be nurtured in adolescent females for they are expected to fulfill many responsibilities stemming from their role as a prospective wife and mother.

One important implication of this study is the finding that there is a connection between gender and personality traits. These results relatively match the results of various Western studies which suggest that women usually tend to show higher mean trait values than men, and that Neuroticism is usually the least prominent trait in a given sample [25].

Thus, the results of this study are in accordance with other studies of the Big Five personality traits model.

It is assumed that these findings have some implications for practice and for further research. This study shows that females generally possess the personality traits necessary to become effective students to a higher degree than males did. This study may act as a useful introduction to the challenging task of developing an education system that aims to not only equip students with knowledge, skills and attitudes, but to also shape them into good citizens and active members of society who are successful in their future. This study may also be helpful in developing students' character and in the development of ways to improve the Big Five personality traits in students' personality. More studies should be conducted to fully examine what plans, activities, procedures, and approaches should be employed in order to achieve this goal. Males need more attention than females since they lack some prominent traits as compared to females. In the future, more research should be conducted to determine the levels of these Big Five personality traits in students and what causes the difference between male and female students' personality traits.

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